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Open Translator's Notes (SIL)

3 John 1:1

Section 1–4: Greetings

Read 1–4 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: As in 2 John 1–3, these verses contain the formal parts of the introduction to a Greek letter, that is, a description of the writer and the person he is writing to, and then a blessing (verse 2). John then goes on to encourage the person he is writing to (Gaius) by saying how pleased he was by the good reports he had heard about Gaius.

1a

The elder,

- ¶ I, the church leader/elder, am writing this letter

1a–b

The elder, To: *(Discourse Feature)* As in 2 John 1, this is a typical beginning for a Greek letter of John's time. However in many languages the writer of a letter introduces himself in the first person singular, "I, the elder, am writing to…." In translation the natural form for starting a letter should be used.

1b

To the beloved Gaius, whom I love in the truth:

- to you, dear Gaius. I truly love you.

the beloved: *(Meaning)* This represents the Greek word which is translated by BSB as "beloved" in 1 John 2:7 and other places in 1 John. It is closely related to the Greek word for "love" and means "dear ones" or "you who I love."

Gaius: *(New Participant)* This is the same name as in Acts 19:29, 20:4, Romans 16:23 and 1 Corinthians 1:14, but probably a different person. Gaius was a very common name in the Roman Empire.

in the truth: *(Alternative Interpretations)* This is the same phrase as in 2 John 1. As in that verse, there are two different interpretations of what it means:

1. It probably means "truly/really." (GNT, NEB, LB, JBP)
2. It may mean "because we all believe in God's truth."

3 John 1:2

Section 1–4: Greetings

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2 *(Focus)*

The focus of this verse is John's wish that all may be well with Gaius in his physical health and in his daily business. He then says that he knows that Gaius' spiritual life is going well.

2a

Beloved, I pray that in every way you may prosper and enjoy good health,

- My dear friend, I hope that you may be well/strong in your body and that you may succeed/prosper in all your affairs/work,

I pray that: *(Multiple Senses)* This verb can be used both in the sense of praying to God and in the sense of wishing or hoping for something. It is probably being used in this second sense here. See JB.

2b

as your soul also prospers.

- just as your spiritual life is doing well in its relationship with God.
- in the same way that you are succeeding at living more in union with God.

soul: *(Figure of Speech)* This word is used here as a figure of speech referring to Gaius' spiritual life, his relationship with God.

3 John 1:3

Section 1–4: Greetings

Read 1–4 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: As in 2 John 1–3, these verses contain the formal parts of the introduction to a Greek letter, that is, a description of the writer and the person he is writing to, and then a blessing (verse 2). John then goes on to encourage the person he is writing to (Gaius) by saying how pleased he was by the good reports he had heard about Gaius.

3a

For I was overjoyed when the brothers came

- I became very happy when/because some fellow Christians came here

the brothers: *(Multiple Senses)* This is used here in the sense of "fellow Christians."

3b

and testified about your devotion to the truth,

- and told us(excl) that you are living in God's true way.
- and told us(excl) how you are doing what God has shown us(incl) he truly wants us to do.

testified about: *(Lexical Problem)* John does not mention here who they told this to. However in verse 6 he mentions that these brothers spoke about Gaius to the whole church in the place where John was.

your devotion to the truth: *(Meaning)* This means Gaius was putting into practice in his daily life the truth about how God wants us to live.

3c

in which you continue to walk.

- And I know that you are in fact living/doing like that always.

in which you continue to walk: *(Alternative Interpretations)* There are different views about whether the last clause of this verse is part of what the brothers reported or whether it is John's comment on their report:

3. It is probably John's comment confirming that Gaius really does live according to God's truth. (GNT, NEB, KJV, RSV, JBP)
4. Some think that it is a second part to the brothers' report, emphasizing that Gaius continually puts God's truth into practice. (BSB, NIV, JB, LB)

you continue to walk: *(Metaphor)* As in 2 John 4, this is a Greek metaphor meaning, "you continue to put into practice in your life the truth which God has revealed about how he wants you to live."

3 John 1:4

Section 1–4: Greetings

Read 1–4 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: As in 2 John 1–3, these verses contain the formal parts of the introduction to a Greek letter, that is, a description of the writer and the person he is writing to, and then a blessing (verse 2). John then goes on to encourage the person he is writing to (Gaius) by saying how pleased he was by the good reports he had heard about Gaius.

4 ***(Logical Connection)***

I have no greater joy than to hear that my children are walking in the truth.

- Whenever I hear that those who are like my children are living according to what God has truly shown us,[(incl)] then that makes me more happy than anything else can.

This verse is giving the reason why the reports about Gaius made John so happy.

I have no greater joy: *(Figure of Speech)* John is here using exaggeration to emphasize that such reports make him very happy.

my children: *(Cross-cultural Difference)* John uses this term here as he does in 1 John to refer to Christians in churches for which he is responsible. See the note on "My little children" in 1 John 2:1.

3 John 1:5

Section 5–12: It is good to help those who teach the truth

Read 5–12 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main points John is writing to Gaius about. He praises Gaius for helping the traveling Christian preachers and encourages him to follow the good example of Demetrius rather than the bad example of Diotrephes.

Paragraph 5–8

Read 5–8 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John praises Gaius for helping the traveling preachers. He explains that Christians should help these people because they are serving Christ and relying on fellow Christians to supply all they need.

5

Beloved, you are faithful in what you are doing for the brothers, and especially since they are strangers to you.

- ¶ My dear friend, you have done many things to help our(incl) fellow Christians who are travelling around preaching the gospel. You even help those who you do not know. This has shown to me that you are a faithful/loyal follower of Christ.

you are faithful: *(Focus)* John is not simply praising Gaius for being faithful. He is saying that the help which Gaius gives to the brothers proves that he is faithful. See the Display.

faithful: *(Lexical Problem)* In your translation you may need to state who Gaius is faithful to John probably means that Gaius is faithful to God or Jesus.

what you are doing: *(Translation)* John does not state exactly what Gaius did, but from the rest of the letter it is clear that he welcomed the brothers into his house and provided them with what they needed.

are doing: *(Tense)* This probably refers both to what Gaius has done in the past for some brothers and to what he is still doing for those who come to him.

strangers: *(Meaning)* The meaning here is that some of the brothers were not previously known to Gaius (they probably came from distant towns or provinces). But he nevertheless helped them just because they were Christians.

3 John 1:6

Section 5–12: It is good to help those who teach the truth

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Paragraph 5–8

Read 5–8 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John praises Gaius for helping the traveling preachers. He explains that Christians should help these people because they are serving Christ and relying on fellow Christians to supply all they need.

6a

They have testified to the church

- Some of these people whom you have helped have told us(excl) people of the church here

They: *(Pronoun Reference)* In the previous verse John referred to the traveling Christian preachers as "brothers." This pronoun *They* refers to some of these brothers, who have come to John after Gaius has helped them.

the church: *(Multiple Senses)* Here this means the group of Christians in the place where John was.

6b

about your love.

- about how you love your fellow Christians very much.

love: *(Event Idea)* In some languages this may be expressed by a verb. You may need to indicate that it refers to Gaius' love for the brothers or all fellow Christians.

6c

You will do well

- Now I say to you that you ought

You will do well: *(Emotive Impact)* This is John's way of requesting Gaius to continue helping the traveling preachers. In translation it must be made clear that this is a request, not just a statement.

6d

to send them on their way

- to continue to help these/such people by giving them what they need when they wish to leave you and travel to other places.

send them on their way: *(Meaning)* This means Gaius should help them and give them whatever they need when they are ready to leave his home and continue their travels.

them: *(Pronoun Reference)* This refers to any traveling Christian preachers who come to Gaius in future, whether they are the same ones who reported about him to John or others like them.

6e

in a manner worthy of God.

- You should do this generously because this is what pleases God.

in a manner worthy of God: *(Alternative Interpretations)* There are different ideas about what this means:

5. It probably means Gaius should help them in the way that God wants his people to help each other. (GNT, JB)
6. Some think it means he should honour them because they are God's representatives.

3 John 1:7

Section 5–12: It is good to help those who teach the truth

Read 5–12 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main points John is writing to Gaius about. He praises Gaius for helping the traveling Christian preachers and encourages him to follow the good example of Demetrius rather than the bad example of Diotrephes.

Paragraph 5–8

Read 5–8 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John praises Gaius for helping the traveling preachers. He explains that Christians should help these people because they are serving Christ and relying on fellow Christians to supply all they need.

7a

For they went out on behalf of the Name,

- For these people are traveling around in order to serve Jesus Christ,

For: *(Logical Connection)* This verse is giving the reason why John requests Gaius to help the brothers.

they went out: *(Lexical Problem)* This refers to their making a journey to preach the gospel in different places. It does not refer to leaving any specific place.

the Name: *(Special Biblical Term)* This is a way of referring to Jesus Christ. This phrase is used a few times in the New Testament. See GNT, NEB.

7b

accepting nothing from the Gentiles.

- and they do not ask for any help from those who are not Christians.

accepting nothing: *(Meaning)* As Christian preachers they did not ask for help from unbelievers. John is showing that they were different from teachers of other religions who traveled around at that time. The teachers of other religions used to require payment from the people they instructed and converted.

3 John 1:8

Section 5–12: It is good to help those who teach the truth

Read 5–12 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main points John is writing to Gaius about. He praises Gaius for helping the traveling Christian preachers and encourages him to follow the good example of Demetrius rather than the bad example of Diotrephes.

Paragraph 5–8

Read 5–8 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John praises Gaius for helping the traveling preachers. He explains that Christians should help these people because they are serving Christ and relying on fellow Christians to supply all they need.

8a

Therefore we ought to support such men,

- Therefore we(incl) Christians ought to give these people whatever they need,

we: *(Pronoun Reference)* John is referring to himself and Gaius and all other Christians. See GNT.

support such men: *(Meaning)* This means Christians should help these people by welcoming them to stay in their homes and giving them whatever they need to continue their work for Christ.

8b

so that we may be fellow workers

- so that we may be partners with them

that we may be fellow workers: *(Pronoun Reference)* John means that by helping these brothers, he and Gaius and all other Christians will be sharing in their work.

8c

for the truth.

- in their work of telling people the true things which God has revealed.

for the truth: *(Alternative Interpretations)* There are different ideas about the meaning of the Greek phrase used here:

7. It probably refers to working with the traveling preachers in spreading God's truth to other people. (GNT, BSB, JB, NEB)
8. Some think it refers to working together with God's truth as it spreads among people. (KJV, JBP)

3 John 1:9

Section 5–12: It is good to help those who teach the truth

Read 5–12 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main points John is writing to Gaius about. He praises Gaius for helping the traveling Christian preachers and encourages him to follow the good example of Demetrius rather than the bad example of Diotrephes.

Paragraph 9–12

Read 9–12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John uses a negative example and a positive example to reinforce what he has said about helping the traveling preachers. He describes Diotrephes, who opposes their work and rejects John's instructions. Then he describes Demetrius, who is respected by all the Christians.

9a

I have written to the church about this,

- ¶ I have previously written a letter to the people of the church at your place/town,

(GNT:) a short letter: *(Text)* After "I have written," many Greek manuscripts have a word meaning "something," or "a little." Several English versions translate this text. Other versions such as BSB follow manuscripts which do not have this text. In your translation it may be best to follow the BSB.

the church: *(Multiple Senses)* Here this means the group of Christians in the place where Diotrephes was. That was probably in the same place where Gaius lived, or nearby.

9b

but Diotrephes, who loves to be first, will not accept our instruction.

- but Diotrephes refuses to accept my instructions because he always wants to be the leader of the church himself.

Diotrephes: *(New Participant)* It is not clear whether Gaius already knew about Diotrephes or not. In translation he should be referred to as someone who has not previously been mentioned in this letter.

loves to be first: *(Connotation)* This implies that even if Diotrephes thinks that he is the leader of the church, John does not recognize him as the leader. He condemns Diotrephes for actively seeking such a position.

first: *(Multiple Senses)* This means being the leader of the church in that place. John does not use either of the biblical terms "bishop" or "elder" here, and at that time Christian leaders were not called pastors or priests. So a more neutral term for a Christian leader should be used in translation here. See GNT, JB, NEB, JBP, LB.

will not accept: *(Meaning)* The Greek word used here means that Diotrephes did not accept or obey what John had written. It implies that he did not accept John's authority to give him instructions. See GNT, RSV, LB.

our: *(Pronoun Reference)* John is here using the plural pronoun to refer to himself. In many languages this may need to be translated as "my."

3 John 1:10

Section 5–12: It is good to help those who teach the truth

Read 5–12 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main points John is writing to Gaius about. He praises Gaius for helping the traveling Christian preachers and encourages him to follow the good example of Demetrius rather than the bad example of Diotrephes.

Paragraph 9–12

Read 9–12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John uses a negative example and a positive example to reinforce what he has said about helping the traveling preachers. He describes Diotrephes, who opposes their work and rejects John's instructions. Then he describes Demetrius, who is respected by all the Christians.

10a

So if I come,

- Therefore, when I come to your place/town

if I come: *(Meaning)* Verse 14 makes it clear that John intends to come, so the word *if* here is probably indicating that he does not yet know when he will come. See GNT, LB.

come: *(Lexical Problem)* In your language it may be necessary to state where John was intending to come to, namely the place where Gaius and Diotrephes were.

10b

I will call attention to

- I will speak openly to the people of the church about what Diotrephes is doing.

call attention to: *(Lexical Problem)* This means that John will tell openly what Diotrephes has been doing. In translation it may be necessary to state that the people who John will tell this to are the members of the church where Diotrephes was.

10c

his malicious slander against us

- What he is doing is this, he is telling foolish lies about me,
- I will show how he is accusing me falsely and foolishly,

his malicious slander: *(Meaning)* This means that Diotrephes had been making foolish and untrue accusations against John.

us: *(Pronoun Reference)* As in verse 9, John is here using the plural pronoun to refer to himself.

10d

And unsatisfied with that, he refuses to welcome the brothers

- And he is also doing something even worse than that. He is refusing to welcome our(incl) fellow Christians who are traveling around preaching the gospel.

And unsatisfied with that: *(Logical Connection)* This phrase is not literally stating anything about what satisfies Diotrephes. It is used to indicate something he does which is even worse than malicious gossip. In translation this can often be indicated by an idiomatic phrase. See GNT, JB, JBP.

the brothers: *(Pronoun Reference)* As in verse 5, this refers to any of the traveling Christian preachers who came to him.

10e

and forbids those who want to do so,

- Also he hinders those people in the church who do want to welcome these traveling Christians.

who want to do so: *(Ellipsis)* This is a short way of saying, "who want to welcome the brothers."

10f

even putting them out of the church.

- And he even expels from the meetings of the church those who want to welcome them.

putting them out of the church: *(Meaning)* This means that Diotrephes expels these members from the church in that place. He somehow prevents them from continuing to have fellowship with that church.

putting them out: *(Pronoun Reference)* This means that Diotrephes expels those church members who wanted to welcome the "brothers." It does not refer to him expelling the "brothers" themselves.

3 John 1:11

Section 5–12: It is good to help those who teach the truth

Read 5–12 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main points John is writing to Gaius about. He praises Gaius for helping the traveling Christian preachers and encourages him to follow the good example of Demetrius rather than the bad example of Diotrephes.

Paragraph 9–12

Read 9–12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John uses a negative example and a positive example to reinforce what he has said about helping the traveling preachers. He describes Diotrephes, who opposes their work and rejects John's instructions. Then he describes Demetrius, who is respected by all the Christians.

11a

Beloved, do not imitate what is evil,

- My dear friend, do not copy the behavior of people who do evil,

do not imitate what is evil: *(Meaning)* Although John is probably thinking of Diotrephes' evil deeds, he is giving this as a general instruction to Gaius, telling him not to copy any evil people or anything they do.

11b

but what is good.

- instead you should copy the behavior of those who do good.

but what is good: *(Ellipsis)* This is a short way of making the positive command, "Imitate what is good."

11c

The one who does good is of God;

- If/When anyone does good, his good deeds show that he is a child of God.

The one who does good is of God: *(Meaning)* John does not mean that if a person does good he becomes a child of God. He is talking about what our deeds show, not what they make us become. He is saying here the same thing as in 1 John 3:10, that our good or bad deeds show whether we belong to God or Satan.

11d

the one who does evil has not seen God.

- But if/when someone does evil, his evil deeds show that he does not know God.

seen: *(Metaphor)* This is the same metaphor as in 1 John 3:6. It refers to recognizing or knowing God.

3 John 1:12

Section 5–12: It is good to help those who teach the truth

Read 5–12 carefully.

Section Theme: This section contains the main points John is writing to Gaius about. He praises Gaius for helping the traveling Christian preachers and encourages him to follow the good example of Demetrius rather than the bad example of Diotrephes.

Paragraph 9–12

Read 9–12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John uses a negative example and a positive example to reinforce what he has said about helping the traveling preachers. He describes Diotrephes, who opposes their work and rejects John's instructions. Then he describes Demetrius, who is respected by all the Christians.

12a

Demetrius has received a good testimony from everyone,

- Everyone in the church says that Demetrius is a good person.

Demetrius: *(New Participant)* This is not the same Demetrius as in Acts 19:24. He is someone who John is introducing to Gaius.

everyone: *(Figure of Speech)* This is an exaggeration. John means everyone in the church, or everyone who knew Demetrius, not everyone everywhere.

12b

and from the truth itself.

- He lives according to the true things which God has revealed, and this proves that he is a good person.
- In all his behavior he does what God has shown us[(incl)] he wants us to do, and so we know that he is a good person.

from the truth itself: *(Figure of Speech)* Here John personifies God's truth as a person who speaks well about Demetrius. He means that Demetrius puts God's truth into practice in his life and this shows that he is a good person.

12c

We also testify for him,

- I also tell you that he is a good person,

12c–d

We…our: *(Pronoun Reference)* John is again referring to himself. See NEB, RSV, LB. See also the note on verse 9.

12d

and you know that our testimony is true.

- and you know that whatever I say about anyone is true.

our testimony: *(Meaning)* This means whatever John says about anyone, including what he says about Demetrius.

3 John 1:13

Section 13–14: Final comments

Read 13–14 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: These verses contain John's final comments and greetings to close the letter.

13a

I have many things to write to you,

- ¶ There are many more things that I would like to tell you,

13b

but I would prefer not to do so with pen and ink.

- but I do not want to write them in a letter like this.

I would prefer not to do so with pen and ink: *(Meaning)* As in 2 John 12, this does not mean that there is anything wrong with using pen and ink. John is just saying that he would prefer to talk with Gaius face to face.

pen and ink: *(Translation)* This is another idiom meaning "in a letter." In your translation you should consider what is the natural way of saying this in your language.

3 John 1:14

Section 13–14: Final comments

Read 13–14 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: These verses contain John's final comments and greetings to close the letter.

14a

Instead, I hope to see you soon

- What I want and expect is that I will come and visit you soon,

14b

and speak with you face to face.

- and then we(incl) will be together and will talk together.

face to face: *(Translation)* As in 2 John 12, this is an idiom which should be translated by a natural phrase for having a friendly personal talk with someone.

3 John 1:15

15

Most English versions except BSB and KJV have the verse number 15 before the sentence beginning with "Peace." In your translation you should follow the verse numbering system of the major version used in your area.

15a (14c in BSB)

(14c in BSB) Peace to you.

- May God cause you to live in peace/quietness.

Peace to you: *(Discourse Feature)* This represents John's wish that Gaius should have God's peace. It is in the form of a standard greeting at the end of a Greek letter, so it should be translated in a way that makes it sound like a farewell greeting.

15b

(14d in BSB) The friends here send you greetings.

- All your friends in the church here are greeting you.

15c

(14e in BSB) Greet each of our friends there by name.

- Please greet for me all my friends in the church at your place/town one by one.

15b–c (14d-e in BSB)

friends here…friends there: *(Meaning)* John is referring to Christian friends, the other members of the churches in the places where he was and where Gaius was.